

SVATANTRA-VIJÑĀNAVĀDA

Comprehensive Scholarly Notes — Chapter Eight

Source: C. D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*

Covers: Introduction · Momentariness · Pramāṇas · Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika Categories · Apoha · Primordial Matter (Prakṛti) · Īśvara · Brahman · Ātman · External Objects / Pure Consciousness · Exposition of the Buddha

I. Introduction

A. Identity, Alternative Names, and the School's Programme

This school is known by three names: **Svatantra-Vijñānavāda**, **Svatantra-Yogācāra**, and **Sautrāntika-Yogācāra**. The triple nomenclature signals its three-fold origin:

- It accepts the **metaphysical truth of Vijñānavāda** — Reality is Pure Consciousness.
- It supports this with **independent logical arguments** (hence 'Svatantra' — autonomous/independent).
- It grafts onto Vijñānavāda the **logical and epistemological Critical Realism of the Sautrāntika School**.

The result: a fusion of metaphysical Idealism with epistemological rigour. Sharma calls it simply **the Logical School of Buddhism**.

B. Founding Figures and Intellectual Succession

- **Diñnāga** — disciple of Vasubandhu; founder of this school and founder of Medieval Indian Logic (occupying the same position as Gotama for Ancient Logic and Gaṅgeśa for Modern Logic).
- **Dharmakīrti** — fully elaborated and explained the system left by Diñnāga.
- **Śāntarakṣita** — developed it almost to perfection; author of the *Tattva-saṅgraha*.
- **Kamalashīla** — Śāntarakṣita's disciple; author of the *Pañjikā* (commentary on *Tattva-saṅgraha*); the last great scholar of Buddhism in India.

Primary sources: Diñnāga's *magnum opus*, the **Pramāṇa-Samuchchaya**, survives only in Tibetan; its first chapter reconstructed into Sanskrit by H. R. Rangaswamy Iyengar.

Dharmakīrti's **Pramāṇa-Vārtika** and Śāntarakṣita's **Tattva-saṅgraha** are available in original Sanskrit.

C. The School as Logic, Epistemology, and Metaphysics Combined

- **Logic**: deals with syllogism (*parārthānumāna*), inference (*svārthānumāna*), and import of words (*apoha*).
- **Epistemology**: undertakes thorough investigation of sense-perception (*pratyakṣa*), the validity of knowledge (*prāmāṇya*), and the Means of Cognition (*pramāṇa*).
- **Metaphysics**: discusses the real nature of sensation and thought, and admits Reality is supra-logical.

D. Historical Dialectic: Opponents and the Polemical Chain

The Naiyāyika and the Mīmāṃsaka were the two major opponents of Buddhism at the time. The polemical chain:

- Diñnāga ruthlessly criticised the Nyāya-Sūtras of Gotama and the Nyāya-Bhāṣya of Vātsyāyana.
- Uddyotakara (in his *Nyāya-Vārtika*) refuted Diñnāga's charges and defended Nyāya.
- Dharmakīrti (in his *Pramāṇa-Vārtika*) demolished all Uddyotakara's arguments so mercilessly that the eminent Advaitin **Vāchaspati Miśra** had to write his *Nyāya-Vārtika-Tātparya-Ṭikā* to 'rescue the old argument-cows of Uddyotakara which were

entangled in the mud of Buddhist criticism'.

- Dharmakīrti's attack on Mīmāṃsā was so damaging that it provoked Kumārila to write his voluminous Sholka-Vārtika to refute Buddhism and defend Mīmāṃsā.
- This in turn gave rise to Śāntarakṣita's Tattva-saṅgraha and Kamalashīla's Pañjikā, which refute extensively the Naiyāyikas (especially Uddyotakara) and the Mīmāṃsakas (especially Kumārila).
- Buddhism could not resist the onslaught of Brāhmanism; Śāntarakṣita was forced to retire to Tibet, calling Kamalashīla too. Kamalashīla was the last great Buddhist scholar in India. The Svatantra-Vijñānavāda school, after producing an enormously rich philosophical literature, came to an end — and with it, Buddhist philosophy in India virtually ended.

Sharma's critical observation: The Svatantra-Vijñānavādins — Diñnāga, Dharmakīrti, Śāntarakṣita — all pay lip-homage to Vasubandhu by confessing they follow his footsteps on ultimate reality. But what they actually do is **undermine the whole metaphysics of Vasubandhu** by degrading his permanent Consciousness to the level of a momentary Vijñāna or a unique momentary Particular which they call Svalakṣaṇa. The Ālayavijñāna and the Vijñaptimātra are completely ignored by them.

II. The Revival of the Doctrine of Momentariness

A. The Two Sources of Knowledge and the Metaphysical Ground

The Logical School maintains sensation and thought are two radically different sources of knowledge:

- **Sensation (pratyakṣa):** reflects the unique, momentary, existent, ultimate reality — the Svalakṣaṇa (unique particular / thing-in-itself).
- **Thought (inference / anumāna):** conceives a chain of moments by constructing relations and images — the Sāmānyalakṣaṇa (universal / general character). It gives only indirect, vague, abstract thought-constructions.

Key equation: Right knowledge = successful/efficacious knowledge. Momentariness = motion or change; efficiency = existence. Therefore:

- The real is the causally efficient; the unreal is the inefficient (Dharmakīrti: *arthakriyāsāmarthyalakṣaṇam paramārthasat*).
- The ultimately existent is the momentary particular 'thing-in-itself' — it is the 'this', the 'here', the 'now', the 'present moment of efficiency'. It is **indescribable and unutterable** because it is shorn of all objectivized images. Everything else has only indirect, borrowed, or second-rate reality. All thought-relations are fictitious.

B. Reality as Change: The Self-Identity of Motion and Existence

A radical set of identifications:

- Existence is efficiency; efficiency is change. The changeless is inefficient and hence unreal.
- **Motion is nothing but the moving thing itself;** efficiency is the efficient thing itself; existence is the unique momentary particular itself. Motion, change, efficiency, existence are only names for the momentary thing-in-itself.

- Similarly, non-existence is only a name for the thing annihilated. Existence and non-existence are thus two different sides of the same reality.

The apparent paradox — reality is motion, yet motion is impossible for momentary things (they have no time to move) — is resolved:

Motion is an illusion because things being momentary have no time to move. Motion is only a series of immobilities. Flashes of energy follow one another giving rise to an illusion of motion. In a stream fresh waters come in every moment; in a lamp a series of different flames presents an illusion of one flame. The apparent contradiction is solved by the fact that motion is not something over and above the moving things. **Things themselves are motion.**

C. Causality Reconceived: Functional Interdependence, Not Real Production

Causality is not real production — it is only functional interdependence:

- The cause does not produce the effect. It has not time to do so. The cause merely precedes the effect; the effect merely follows the cause.
- Existence is efficiency; efficiency itself is the cause. Things arise **neither out of self nor out of not-self nor out of both nor out of neither**. They are not produced at all — effects are merely functionally dependent on their causes.
- All dharmas are therefore inactive and forceless (nirvyāpārāḥ akiñchit-karāḥ sarvadharmāḥ).
- The seeming contradiction (Reality is efficiency; all elements are inactive) is solved by the fact that there is no efficiency over and above existence — existence itself is causal efficiency (*sattaiva vyāpṛtiḥ*).

Causality as invariable antecedence (ānantaryaniyama): The mere existence of the cause is the efficient causal operation. Cause being present, effect necessarily follows. Causality = the determination of the succeeding states by the preceding states.

D. Dharmakīrti's Doctrine: Everything Is Momentary — Annihilation Uncaused

- Whatever is produced must be destroyed. That which comes into existence and afterwards ceases is called momentary.
- Reality is annihilation. Change exists by itself and always.
- **Annihilation does not require any cause** — because annihilation is uncaused, it automatically follows everything. This is because annihilation does not mean the destruction of a positive entity. When we say a thing is destroyed, what we mean is simply that the thing is momentary.

E. Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla on Destruction: Two Kinds Distinguished

They maintain destruction is neither an entity nor a non-entity. Two kinds of destruction:

- **Kṣaṇa-sthiti-dharma-rūpa-vināśa** — 'momentary character of a thing' = *transcendental impermanence*. This has a cause: an entity itself is the cause of its own destruction, because the very fact that a momentary entity is produced implies it is destroyed. There can be no other cause.

- **Dhvaṃsa-rūpa-nāśa** — 'disruption' = *empirical annihilation*. This is causeless. When we say there is empirical annihilation of a thing, we mean simply that the thing is not there. This destruction does not convey the affirmation of anything.

Kṣaṇa is **not a time-moment**. It is the character of being destroyed immediately after being produced. The very nature of a thing to disappear after existing for one moment is called 'Kṣaṇa'. That thing which has this nature is called 'Kṣaṇika'. There is absolutely no difference between the momentary character and the thing possessing it — the momentary character itself is the momentary thing. The distinction is entirely a product of intellect and creation of language, justified only conventionally.

F. Impossibility of Permanent Entities: The Dilemma of Simultaneous Production

Only a momentary thing can exist because only it can be efficient. A permanent entity is inefficient and hence unreal:

- A permanent entity should produce all its effects **simultaneously** — because the efficient cause being present, there is no reason why its effects should be delayed.
- If a permanent entity can produce successive effects because of its association with successive accessories (krāmiṇaḥ sahkāriṇaḥ), then the question arises: do the accessories work by producing a peculiar modification (atīśaya) in the permanent cause, or independently?
- If the modification is *identical* with the permanent cause: then it is this peculiar modification, not the permanent entity, which is the cause.
- If the modification is *different* from the permanent cause: how can it be related to the permanent entity?
- If accessories work *independently*: how can a permanent cause tolerate the independent functioning of accessories?
- The relation between permanent cause and accessories cannot be of identity (tādātmya), productivity (tadutpatti), or inherence (samavāya) — only of assistance (upakāra). But then either the accessories are also permanent and should give rise to simultaneous creation, or they are useless.

G. Naiyāyika / Mīmāṃsaka Objections and the Buddhist Replies

Objections: If things are momentary —

- The theory of Karma is thrown overboard — an action is done by one while its result befalls another.
- Recognition cannot be explained — there is no perceiver who can compare the present with the past.
- How can a momentary cause, which does not abide till the production of the effect, produce it?
- How can bondage or liberation belong to a momentary entity? Are not all efforts for liberation futile?

Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla reply:

- **Identity = only similarity.** Recognition is due to memory and memory is due to false imagination. A 'flame' is nothing but a series of different flames appearing and disappearing

every moment — we call it the 'same flame' only conventionally.

- The notion of 'doer' or 'enjoyer' becomes possible in reference to the supposed 'unity of the chain or the series' — this unity is only a creation of the intellect, not real.
- The formula of causation is 'this being produced, that is produced'. The preceding states produce the subsequent states. The cause perishes in the second moment — *after* it has produced the effect, not before. The causal efficiency ceases immediately after production of the effect. The Vaibhāṣikas maintain the effect is produced at the third moment — but in our view: the cause exists in the first moment and produces the effect in the second moment and immediately after producing it the cause ceases to exist. Cause and effect cannot be simultaneous.
- **Bondage** = the series of painful states produced by ignorance; **liberation** = the cessation of this series and the consequent purity of mental states produced by right knowledge.
- The theory of Momentariness repudiates at one stroke all metaphysical permanent entities like Primordial Matter, Self, God, etc.

III. The Pramāṇas (Means of Cognition)

A. Only Two Valid Pramāṇas

Conforming to the two kinds of Prameyas (objects of cognition) — (1) the direct unique Particular given in pure sensation, and (2) the indirect vague Universal given in thought-construction — there are only two valid Pramāṇas:

- **Perception (pratyakṣa)**
- **Inference (anumāna)**

B. Exposition of Perception

Nyāya definition: perception is that non-illusory cognition produced by the contact of the senses with external objects. This is rejected by the Svatantra-Vijñānavādin since external objects do not exist outside thought.

Diñnāga's definition: perception = devoid of all thought-determinations, names, universals (kalpanāpoḍha). He drops the adjective 'Non-illusory' (abhrānta) used by Asaṅga as merely superfluous — the idea of non-illusoriness is already conveyed by 'devoid of all thought-determinations'.

Vaiśeṣika position (rejected): An object qualified by five real predicables — generality, particularity, relation, quality, and action — is given in perception, which has two moments: (1) pure sensation (ālōchana-mātra) and (2) determination. The Naiyāyika develops this into indeterminate (nirvikalpa) and determinate (savikalpa) perception. Diñnāga condemns these five predicables as mere fictions of the intellect. The only object of perception is the unique momentary thing-in-itself shorn of all relations.

Dharmakīrti's modification: reintroduces 'non-illusory' (abhrānta) to specifically exclude sense-illusions like the perception of the double-moon (distinct from the illusions of thought). He therefore defines perception as devoid of all thought-determinations *and illusions*. Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla agree with Dharmakīrti — perception = devoid of illusion and determination (which is the conceptual content).

C. Exposition of Inference

The nerve of inference is **Vyāpti** (inseparable connection). In inference, an object is cognized through its 'mark' or valid 'middle term' which has **three characteristics**:

- (1) it is present in the *probandum* (anumeya),
- (2) it is also present in that which is like the *probandum*,
- (3) it is absent in that which is not like the *probandum*.

Inference for another (*parārthānumāna*) is a syllogism. The Nyāya syllogism has five members: (1) Thesis, (2) Reason, (3) Example with inseparable connection, (4) Application, (5) Conclusion.

Diñnāga and his followers reject Thesis, Reason, and Conclusion and retain only two: (1) Example with Inseparable Connection / the General Rule, and (2) Application which includes Reason and Conclusion.

Note: Prof. Dhruva has shown that Diñnāga cannot be credited with the invention of Vyāpti — the doctrine was held by Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika long before him.

Critical limit of inference: For Diñnāga and followers, the validity of inference is only on the phenomenal plane. Inference has no reference to ultimate reality which is indescribable and beyond all thought-determinations.

D. Criticism of Other Pramāṇas

The Svatantra-Vijñānavādins maintain the validity of perception and inference only. All other Pramāṇas can be either reduced to these two or are no Pramāṇas at all:

- **Verbal Testimony (śabda):** valid only if it can be tested at the touch-stone of reason.
- **Analogy (upamāna):** a combination of perception and memory — reducible to the two.
- **Implication (arthāpatti):** can be easily reduced to inference. Example: 'All fat persons who do not eat during day eat during night' (major premise) → 'Devadatta is fat and does not eat during day' (minor) → 'Therefore Devadatta eats during night' (conclusion).
- **Negation (abhāva):** either a non-entity or is included in perception.
- Other Pramāṇas are no Pramāṇas at all.

E. Criticism of the Veda (Anti-Mīmāṃsā Arguments)

The Mīmāṃsaka maintains the Veda is eternal — words, meanings, relationships, injunctions, prohibitions are all eternal; the Veda has neither a before nor after; it is authorless and eternal.

Buddhist refutation (Dharmakīrti, Śāntarakṣita, Kamalashīla):

- Only a person can speak, write, or understand words. The Veda itself cannot reveal its meaning. Because we do not remember the authors, does it follow the Veda is not the creation of persons? By this logic, many other works whose authors are not known would also have to be regarded as authorless — and absolute reliability would have to be attached to words of heterodox outsiders and to those horrible customs of the Mlechchhas or the Pārasīkas (like marrying one's own mother or daughter), the origin of which is not remembered.
- If the Mīmāṃsaka gives peculiar meanings to ordinary words like 'Svarga', 'Urvashī' etc., who can check us if we say the Vedic sentence 'One who desires heaven should perform sacrifice' means 'One should eat the flesh of a dog' or 'Buddha is omniscient'?

- The argument that because some sentences of the Veda are true, therefore the entire Veda is true — is clearly wrong, because some sentences even of a trustworthy person may be wrong while some sentences even of an untrustworthy person may be right. Only the true words of trustworthy persons which do not contradict our experience should be recognised as the Āgama.
- If the Mīmāṃsaka is really eager to establish the authority of the Veda, he should prove that the Veda is the work of some faultless author of supra-normal vision who has risen above all ignorance. Words embodying truth and goodness, emanating from persons highly intelligent and merciful, do claim validity.

On Śāstra vs. perception/inference: The authority of inference is unquestionable. An inference firmly rooted in facts cannot be set aside by the 'Revealed Word'. The words of the Śāstra whose truth is proved by reasoning, and the true words of any other trustworthy person including oneself, are of equal validity. Dharmakīrti: in respect of those things whose truth can be proved by perception or inference, even if we ignore the Śāstra there is absolutely no harm; and in respect of those things whose truth cannot be verified by perception or inference, the Śāstra too is impotent.

Vivid analogy: 'A husband with his own eyes saw his wife in an undesirable position with another person. When he rebuked her, she cried — Oh friends, see the utter folly of my husband. He relies on his bubble-like eyes and refuses to believe the words of his faithful wife! To have blind faith in every word of the Śāstra even at the expense of perception and inference is like believing a corrupt woman at the cost of one's own eyes.'

IV. Criticism of the Categories of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika

A. Substance (Dravya)

A substance (dravya) is neither the same as nor different from its qualities (guṇa). When we perceive anything, say a cloth, we see only the qualities like colour, length, breadth, thickness, smoothness — we do not see any material substance. There are also no 'wholes' or composite objects apart from parts. Only parts are real because we perceive only parts, attributes, qualities. Without seeing the dewlap, horns, hoofs etc., we do not see 'the cow'.

Test case: If ten pieces of gold are heated into a lump, there is no difference in the weight. If the 'whole' has anything besides the parts, the weight should have increased. And if the 'whole' is nothing over and above the parts, then the ten different pieces should be called a lump.

On eternal atoms: if there are eternal atoms, all things should be produced from them either now or never, either all at once or not at all. The words 'substance' and 'atom' are only conventional — we may give the name 'Lord' to a beggar.

B. The Six Categories and Their Relations

The six categories and their properties cannot be related. The relation between them can be neither of conjunction (restricted to substance) nor of inherence. When 'substance' does not exist, then qualities etc. which depend on it also do not exist. The relation of inherence (samavāya) by which qualities are supposed to be related to substance is a myth.

C. Action (Karma)

The category of action is also unreal because things being momentary have no time to move. And if things are permanent, they cannot move. Motion requires that a thing moves at one time and does not move at another — making it two different things. Whether things are momentary or permanent, motion is in both cases an impossibility (Śāntarakṣita). Because there are no 'substances', there can be no specific particulars (viśeṣa) — they are mere moments.

D. Inherence (Samavāya)

Inherence is supposed to be the relation between parts and whole, held to be eternal because its cause is not known. But parts do not exist apart from the whole and there is no whole over and above its parts. If cloth is different from threads then it should appear in potsherds also; if cloth is not different from threads, the latter should be called cloth. Again, if inherence is eternal, then all things should become eternal. The refutation of substance, qualities, and motion implies the refutation of Universal (sāmānya), which is supposed to reside in these three categories.

E. The Universal (Sāmānya): A Figment of Imagination

The Universal is a mere figment of imagination. Diñnāga:

'It is great dexterity that what (the universal) resides in one place should, without moving from that place, reside in what comes to exist in a place other than that place. It is joined with this thing (which is now coming into existence) in the place where the thing in question is; and yet it does not fail to pervade the thing which is in *that* place. Is not this very wonderful? It does not *go* there — and it was not there before; and yet it is there afterwards — although it is not manifold, and does not quit its former receptacle. What a series of difficulties!'

Words depend on mere usage (Dharmakīrti). Reality is the individual cow; 'the universal cow' is a figment of imagination. The reality of the absolutely dissimilar individuals is covered by the imagined universal. The universal is therefore the result of the 'covering' (saṃvṛti) of the intellect — a practical necessity. If every individual was to be named, names would have enormously increased and it would have been impossible and fruitless. So wise persons resorted to conventional names and coined the Universal. Śāntarakṣita: the universal is a mere convention — people use the term 'cow' (go) in respect of an object which serves the purpose of yielding milk etc. A convention in regard to that term is established. It is a mere name.

Conclusion on Reality: Reality is the unique and absolutely dissimilar particular thing-in-itself. Intellect, words, names, concepts cannot even touch it. The whole business of *probandum* and *probans*, of substance and qualities, of unity and difference, belongs to the empirical reality, not to the absolute momentary thing-in-itself. Reality neither gets united nor does it differ. It cannot be the object of discursive intellect. Reality is one particular thing-in-itself — how can intellect, which is diversity, grasp it? It cannot be grasped by names and concepts for it transcends language and intellect. The more an object of intellect is dialectically examined, the more will it give way.

V. Exposition of the Doctrine of Apoha

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A. The Core Thesis: All Words Are Negative

Diñnāga says all words, all names, all concepts are necessarily relative and so unreal. A word can be described only negatively — it can express its meaning only by rejecting the opposite meaning. A 'cow' means a 'not non-cow'. Names give us universals which are purely imaginary. Names are therefore illusory and negative. They do not touch Reality which is real and affirmative, though ultimately it transcends both affirmation and negation and all categories of the intellect.

Dharmakīrti too repeatedly stresses that the thing-in-itself is beyond language and intellect and that names and concepts are pure imagination — they express themselves only through negation. Śāntarakṣita: conceptual notions and verbal expressions have no real basis; their only basis is purely subjective imagination.

The very essence of unique existents is that the object of a word is never apprehended. Neither the thing-in-itself, nor the universal, nor the relation to the universal, nor something which possesses the universal, nor the form of the cognition of the object can really be called the import of words. The thing-in-itself cannot be denoted by words for it is beyond all convention, language and intellect. And others are only a figment of the imagination.

B. Objection from Naiyāyikas and Mimāṃsakas

The opponents object: the Buddhists, in maintaining that the word 'cow' denotes the universal 'negation of the non-cow', admit by this very expression the reality of the universal 'cow' as an entity. In fact, non-existence implies existence and negation necessarily pre-supposes affirmation. The cognition of the meaning of words is always positive; it is never of the nature of Apoha. If the negation of a negation is different from it, then it is a positive thing; if not, then cow becomes the same as the non-cow.

C. Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla's Reply: Two Kinds of Negation

Negation is of two kinds:

- (1) **Relative negation / exclusion (paryudāsa)** — of two sub-kinds: (a) due to difference of idea (buddhyātma), and (b) due to difference of object (arthātma).
- (2) **Absolute negation / denial (niṣedha)**.

Things are absolutely dissimilar, yet on account of certain well-defined potencies (niyata-śakti) some of them become the basis of the conception of similarity. On account of this basis there arises a **reflection (pratibimbaka)** in cognition which is wrongly grasped as 'an object'. Apoha is the conception of this reflection. The denotative function of the word consists only in the production of this reflection. When this reflection is cognized, the 'exclusion of other objects' follows by implication (sāmarthyā). The notion of 'other objects' is not a part of the reflection. Thus only the relative negation is directly cognized while the absolute negation is indirectly cognized by implication. Thus there is no affirmation without negation.

Apoha is the denotation of the word; the positive universal is a false creation of the intellect. Words are neither synonymous nor not-synonymous because they denote neither unity nor plurality. In fact unity and plurality belong to real things only. Exclusions are cognized by conceptual contents which are the result of conventional ignorance. And these conceptual contents only, not things, differ among themselves. Things-in-themselves are neither unified nor

diversified — it is only the conceptual content that appears as diverse.

The object 'cow' and the object 'non-cow' both are separate realities. Their reality is well-established. It is only the word which is unreal because it depends on the pure whim of the person using it. Words do not cognize external objects — they cognize only their own reflections. On account of the force of ignorance, words mistake their own internal reflections to be external objects.

Words can reflect individuals only — individuals may be denoted by words. But words cannot reflect universals. Universals can be neither denoted nor excluded by words. And even if they are excluded they cannot become real. When a thing excludes another, it is called its Apoha. But by this, neither the thing becomes negative nor does the Apoha really become positive.

Final position: The 'cow' which is a 'negation of the non-cow' is a positive entity and is different from the non-cow. But from the phenomenal standpoint, Apohās are recognised as positive and so cannot be taken to be mere nonentities. From the ultimate standpoint however there can be no object which may be denoted by Apoha — for there is neither that which denotes nor that which is denoted. Things being momentary, all this business is impossible.

VI. Criticism of Primordial Matter (Prakṛti) of Sāṅkhya

A. The Sāṅkhya Position and Its Five Arguments

The Sāṅkhya maintains the existence of an eternal Prakṛti / Pradhāna / Avyakta because: all individual things are limited and finite; they imply a common cause; one eternal Matter transforms itself into various evolutes; there is a distinction between cause and effect; and the unity of the universe points to a single cause. The effect must pre-exist in the cause. Five arguments for Satkāryavāda:

- (1) The non-existent, like the sky-lotus, cannot be produced.
- (2) The cause is always implied.
- (3) Everything cannot be produced by everything.
- (4) The efficient alone can produce that for which it is efficient.
- (5) The effect is the essence of the cause.

B. Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla's Refutation

The arguments adduced by Sāṅkhya against Asat-kāryavāda can be urged with equal force against Satkāryavāda:

- (1) The effect does not pre-exist in the cause — the existent cannot be produced as its production will be a vain repetition; if curd pre-exists in milk then milk should taste like curd.
- (2) Because there is nothing to be produced, there can be no implication of the cause.
- (3) No specific cause.
- (4) No efficient cause.
- (5) No essence or operation of the cause.

Asat-kāryavāda too is a misnomer — we do not advocate the production of a non-entity. What is produced is a thing itself which, before its production, was non-existent. Reality itself is efficient

causation. Production means 'becoming a thing'. This production has no connection with existence or non-existence — it is related only to a non-existent concept. The seed of this conception is the fact that a thing which exists for one moment only was non-existent in the preceding moment. Production is the 'own essence' of a thing which exists for one moment only, irrespective of all connection with the past and the future.

Even if the three qualities (guṇas) are admitted, the existence of an eternal Prakṛti is not proved. An eternal is inefficient and can never be a cause — then creation should be simultaneous. If accessories are admitted, then either they (and not eternal Matter) are the causes, or they are useless. It is highly absurd that Prakṛti knows only to perform and not to enjoy. According to us, everything cannot be produced out of everything because the potency in the causes varies — so without taking recourse to Prakṛti, we can explain the diversity in effects and causes by diversity in the potencies.

VII. Criticism of God (Īśvara)

A. Dharmakīrti's Central Arguments

- An eternal God cannot be regarded as the cause of this world. To Chaitra, a weapon causes a wound and a medicine heals that up — both are regarded as causes because they are momentary and capable of successful activity. God is neither momentary nor efficient.
- If the opponent is so fond of taking an inactive and inefficient entity like God to be the cause of this world, he should better hold a dry trunk of a tree as the cause of this universe.
- God is eternal and so He cannot change. And unless He changes, He cannot be a cause.
- Moreover, it is difficult to understand why an eternal God should acquire the power to become the cause only at a particular time when He starts the creation.
- An effect arises from a combination of causes and conditions. If any other thing except that particular combination is wrongly regarded as the cause, infinite regress is bound to creep in — we shall have to search for a cause of God Himself, and then another cause of that cause, and so on *ad infinitum*.
- The argument 'creation implies the Creator, just as a pot implies a potter' is answered by pointing out that though an effect pre-supposes a cause, yet all effects do not pre-suppose the same cause — otherwise from fog we shall infer fire and even an ant-hill will be regarded as the work of a potter. The capacity to produce an effect lies in a combination of causes, not in eternal things like God.

B. Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla's Additional Arguments

- When there are no composite objects in this world, how can there be an Intelligent Being who is supposed to produce them? It is like proving that an ant-hill is the creation of a potter.
- Objects like houses, stair-cases, gates, towers etc. are made by persons who are many and who have fleeting ideas. If the opponent means only that all effects presuppose an intelligent cause, we have no quarrel — we also maintain that this diverse universe is the result of intelligent actions. We only refute his one Intelligent and Eternal Creator.
- Logically his eternal Creator should have His own cause and this cause should have another cause and so on *ad infinitum*. Again, either God is a nonentity like a sky-lotus and so incapable of producing anything, or the entire creation should be simultaneous. If God depends on

accessories, He is not independent; if He does not, then creation should be simultaneous.

Why should God create at all?

- If He is determined by someone else, He is not free.
- If prompted by compassion, He should have made the world absolutely happy and not full of misery, poverty, grief and pain. Moreover, before creation there were no objects for whom compassion might have been felt.
- If guided in creating/destroying by good/bad actions of persons, He is not free.
- If He creates through sport, He is not even master of His own amusement as He depends on His playful instincts.
- If creation is due to His very existence/nature, there must be simultaneous production.
- If He has no power to create in the beginning, He cannot acquire it afterwards.
- If like a spider gradually producing webs out of its very nature, God also gradually produces this world — this is wrong, because a spider does not, by its very nature, produce webs. What produces them is the saliva which comes out of the mouth of the spider on account of its eager desire to eat insects.
- If creation emanates from God unintentionally, how can God be called intelligent? Even a fisherman thinks twice before he acts.

The arguments which refute Prakṛti and Īśvara also refute their joint causality as admitted by Yoga. Nor can creation be at random without any cause — even the lotus and its filaments, sharpness of thorns, beauty of peacock-feathers etc. are caused by seeds, earth, water etc.

VIII. Criticism of Brahman

A. The Advaita Position and the Buddhist Refutation

If Brahman in itself is an undifferentiated unity and appears as diversity only because of Ignorance, we urge (Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla):

- This unity is neither proved by perception nor by inference.
- Moreover, Brahman cannot even produce a cognition, for consciousness is successive and momentary. Brahman is therefore like the son of a barren woman.
- If Brahman is always of the nature of Pure Consciousness, then Ignorance and its result bondage are impossible — all persons without the least effort on their part will be emancipated.
- If Ignorance is regarded as the essential nature of Brahman, then liberation will be impossible.
- Ignorance cannot be viewed as something apart from and independent of Brahman — then the monism will be destroyed.
- It is improper to describe Ignorance as 'indescribable', or even as something which can be described 'neither as existent nor as non-existent', because in order to be an entity, Ignorance must be either existent or non-existent.
- Because Brahman is one, bondage of one means the bondage of all and liberation of one means the liberation of all.

Buddhist alternative: For us, Ignorance is a disposition or force of false attachment. For us bondage means a series of defiled cognitions produced by Ignorance, while liberation

means a series of pure cognitions produced by Right Knowledge.

IX. Criticism of the Self (Ātman)

A. Of the Self of the Followers of the Upaniṣads (Advaita)

The Advaitins who follow the Upaniṣads maintain that one eternal Consciousness is the only reality which illusorily appears as subject and object. Śāntarakṣita says this view contains only a very slight error — and that error is that this Pure Self which is Pure Consciousness is regarded as *eternal*. The Buddhist refutation:

- We perceive only changing cognitions — apart from them there is no eternal cognition.
- If there were only one eternal consciousness, how can the diverse cognitions be explained? They too will have to be cognized all at once.
- If ultimate reality is one eternal consciousness, then all distinction between wrong and right knowledge, between bondage and liberation, will be wiped off.
- All Yogic practices for right knowledge and consequent liberation will be useless.

B. Of the Self of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika

The Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika School maintains ideas must have a self which knows them and in which all desires, feelings, and ideas inhere. Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla:

- Knowledge does not require a knower for its illumination.
- Desires, feelings, and ideas do not require a receptacle like material things — they are regarded as immobile by the opponents themselves.
- Consciousness itself when associated with the notion of the Ego is called the Self. It has only phenomenal reality. Ultimately it denotes nothing.
- Desires, feelings, and ideas are momentary and arise in succession like the material seed, sprout, creeper etc. They do not need any permanent self to inhere.

C. Of the Self of Mīmāṃsā (Kumārila's Position and Refutation)

Kumārila maintains: just as a snake remains a snake though sometimes coiled and sometimes straight, similarly the self is essentially of the nature of eternal and pure Consciousness, though it may pass through many phases of feelings, volitions, and thoughts. Self-consciousness proves the existence of the Self; the fact of recognition repudiates the No-soul theory.

Buddhist objection: if the Self is one eternal Consciousness, then all cognitions will have to be regarded as one and eternal. **Kumārila's reply:** the diversity of cognitions is due to the diversity of objects — just as fire burns only those combustible objects presented to it, and just as a mirror reflects only those objects put before it, similarly the Self apprehends only those sense-data presented to it by sense-organs.

Buddhist rejoinder:

- If cognitions are influenced by the changing functions of sense-organs and sense-objects, they cannot be regarded as one and eternal.
- Moreover, the diversity of cognitions in dreams and hallucinations where there is no objective counterpart will not be explained.

- If fire burns all combustible objects, then the whole world will be at once reduced to ashes.
- A mirror or crystal which is itself momentary is only an apparatus to produce an illusory image.
- If the changing feelings, volitions, and thoughts are identical with the Self, then the Self will not be permanent; and if they are different from the Self, how can their change affect the Self?
- The simile of the snake is also wrong — the snake becomes coiled etc. because it is itself momentary. Had it been permanent like the Self, it could have never changed.
- In fact the Self or the ego-notion is due to beginningless ignorance. There is no apprehender of the notion of 'I'. Hence there is no knower. Recognition is based on the false notion of memory and it cannot prove the existence of the Self.

D. Of the Self of Sāṅkhya

Sāṅkhya maintains that the Self is pure and eternal consciousness and is different from buddhi or the faculty of cognition. Buddhist objection:

- If the Self only enjoys what is reflected in buddhi, then are these reflections identical with or different from the Self? If identical, then the Self should also change with the reflections; if not, then the Self cannot enjoy them.
- If actions belong to buddhi while fruits belong to the Self, then the charge of vicarious suffering stands.
- If Prakṛti and Puruṣa work together like the blind and the lame, and Prakṛti gives fruits to Puruṣa according to his desires — how is it that many times an intense desire for a thing is felt but the desired thing is absent?
- At the time of enjoyment, if there is modification in the Puruṣa, he is not eternal; and if there is no modification in him, Prakṛti can be of no help to him.
- If Prakṛti brings about this diverse creation in accordance with the Self's 'desire to see', then how can Prakṛti be called Unconscious? To hold that Prakṛti only knows to prepare delicious dishes but does not know to eat them is highly absurd.
- Indeed, intellect, volition, consciousness, knowledge, sentience are all synonyms. There is no harm if Consciousness is described as the Self. We only object to its being called *eternal*.

E. Of the Self of the Jainas

The Jainas maintain the Self is Consciousness but regard it as an Identity-and-difference. As substance (dravya) it is identity and inclusive (anugamātmaka); as 'successive factors' (paryāya), it is diversity and exclusive (vyāvṛttimat), just as a Man-Lion (Nara-Siṃha), though one, has a double nature.

Buddhist refutation (Dharmakīrti): Either pure identity alone or pure difference alone can be logically maintained. Both cannot exist side by side in the same entity. Man-Lion too is not of a double nature — he is only an aggregate of fleeting atoms. The Jainas make such non-sensical and contradictory remarks that Reality is both existence and non-existence, unity and plurality, inclusion and exclusion. If it is so, then curd is curd as well as a camel — then when a person is asked to eat curd, he should run to eat a camel!

F. Of the Self of the Vātsīputrīyas (Pudgalavādins)

These Hīnayānists, though calling themselves Buddhists (saugatammanyāḥ), uphold the Self under the name of Pudgala and declare it to be neither identical with nor different from the five skandhas, to be neither real nor unreal and hence to be indescribable.

Buddhist refutation (Śāntarakṣita):

- The Pudgala is like a sky-lotus — it is ultimately unreal. In order to be an 'entity' a thing must be either real or unreal. Only a non-entity like a sky-lotus can be called 'indescribable'.
- Efficiency or successful activity is the definition of existence. Only a momentary thing can be efficient and therefore real. The indescribable cannot be called an existent entity.
- Great persons like Vasubandhu have successfully explained the seemingly contradictory teachings of the Merciful Buddha by pointing out that the apparently contradictory teachings are due to his Excellent Skill — that he provisionally taught the existence of the Pudgala only to remove the false notion of non-existence.

X. Criticism of External Objects and Exposition of the Doctrine that Reality is Pure Consciousness

A. Diñnāga's Ālambana-parīkṣā

Diñnāga criticises the atoms of the Vaibhāṣikas and the Vaiśeṣikas using arguments similar to those of Vasubandhu in the Viṃśatikā. Consciousness is the only reality. The so-called external objects do not exist independently and outside of consciousness.

Consciousness manifests itself as the subject as well as the object. The so-called external object is only the 'knowable-aspect' (grāhya-bhāga) or the 'object-condition' (ālambana-pratyaya) of consciousness. Its **objectivity is not denied** — it is said to appear as object to the knowing subject. Only its objectivity does not fall outside of consciousness.

Opponent's objection: if the object is a part of consciousness and appears simultaneously with it, how can it be a condition to consciousness itself?

Diñnāga's answer: the object, the essence of which is consciousness and which is only the knowable-aspect of consciousness, appears *as if* it is something external and also serves as a condition to consciousness because of its invariable association with consciousness and also because of its transmitting the force in succession. The sense-organ is only the force in consciousness which acts as an auxiliary cause to enable consciousness to manifest itself. This force is not something opposed to consciousness — it is inside consciousness itself. Thus the object (only the knowable-aspect of consciousness) and the sense-organ (only the force of consciousness) go on determining each other from beginningless time.

B. Dharmakīrti on External Objects as Relative Existence

- An object is nothing but relative existence, and the latter is nothing but dependence on causes and conditions. The form in which consciousness manifests itself under causes and conditions is called an 'external object'.
- The diversity among intellects is due to the different mental dispositions (saṃskāra) or forces (vāsanā), and not to the so-called plurality of external objects.

- When it is proved that consciousness itself appears as an object, Dharmakīrti says he does not know through what beginningless ignorance an external object is taken to be real! Indeed to those whose vision is blurred by magic, small round potsherds look like coins and pebbles look like diamonds.
- It is only when philosophers, like elephants, close their eyes to the ultimate reality and descend on the phenomenal plane that they take external objects as a practical necessity.

C. The Non-Dual Pure Consciousness: Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla

Reality is Pure Consciousness. It manifests itself internally as subject and externally as object.

But the distinction between internal and external is **within** Consciousness itself —

Consciousness is a unity. Its manifestation as subject and object is therefore only an appearance, not reality. The subject-aspect and object-aspect of Consciousness are mutually relative — one without the other is unreal.

- Reality which is this non-dual Pure Consciousness ultimately transcends the subject-object duality.
- Everything which can be defined, which can be brought under the categories of intellect, is an appearance and does not fall outside the subject-object duality. Appearances are declared to be unreal because they are indefinable.
- It is only through Ignorance that non-dual Pure Consciousness appears as the duality of subject and object.
- Like the external object, the internal subject is also unreal — it is the ego-notion and is the root-cause of all suffering.
- The real Self is self-luminous Consciousness; all impurities are adventitious.

Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla call themselves **Nirākāra-Vijñānavādins** or upholders of Formless Consciousness. Śāntarakṣita frankly confesses that the fact that Pure Consciousness is the ultimate reality has been clearly established by eminent Āchāryas like Vasubandhu in his Vijñaptimātratā-siddhi and like Dinnāga in his Ālambana-parīkṣā, and that so far as ultimate reality is concerned he is following the same path. Whether consciousness arises as formless (anirābhāsa) or with form (sanirābhāsa) or with something else (anyanirābhāsa), the fact is that it can never cognize any external object for the simple reason that such object does not really exist. Consciousness needs nothing else for apprehension.

Self-consciousness means the necessarily non-unconscious character of consciousness — knowledge is essentially self-luminous. The objection of Kumārila that cognition is illuminative yet needs a potent external object for its function of apprehension is answered: there is no distinction between cognition and its function; cognition means apprehension of the object and therefore it needs neither any other function nor any external object.

Consciousness ultimately transcends the subject-object duality. It is 'without a second' (advaya). It needs neither a knowing subject nor a known object. It is essentially self-luminous. This pure Consciousness is in fact the Pure Self. True knowledge consists in the realisation of this Pure Self (vishuddhātma-darshana) and it arises when it is known that Ultimate Reality is Pure Consciousness which is devoid of all adventitious impurities. This is the highest Truth taught by the Buddha, the Expounder of Truth.

XI. Exposition of the Buddha

A. Dharmakīrti's Salutation and the Three Bodies

With all religious fervour, Dharmakīrti salutes the Buddha whom he declares to be:

- **Pure Consciousness transcending all categories of the intellect** (vidhūtakalpanājāla — from whom the net of thought-constructions has been cleared away).
- **Samantasphuranatvit** — from whom rays of Consciousness burst forth in every direction.
- **Pure Existence (dharmakāya).**
- **Deep and Pure Bliss (gambhīrodharā-mūrti)** — i.e., Sambhogakāya.
- **Full of compassion on all sides (samantabhadra)** — i.e., Nirmāṇakāya.

B. Dharmakīrti's Denial of Omniscience and Śāntarakṣita's Disagreement

In strict conformity with his acute logic, Dharmakīrti is forced to say that the Buddha is absolutely reliable — **not because he is omniscient, but because he possesses true knowledge (jñānavān), because he is full of compassion (kāruṇikah) and because he is overwhelmingly kind (dayāvān).** His words are not false because, having realised true knowledge and the right path, he has prescribed them for all to practise.

Dharmakīrti **denies omniscience even to the Buddha.** A reliable person should be neither omniscient nor far-sighted — omniscience in this world is impossible. If far-sightedness is the criterion of truth, then let us all adore the vultures!

Śāntarakṣita **strongly differs** from Dharmakīrti on this point and emphatically declares the Buddha to be Omniscient.

C. The Mīmāṃsaka Challenge to Omniscience and Śāntarakṣita's Full Reply

Mīmāṃsaka objection: An omniscient Being is impossible. One cannot know even all the atoms and the hair of one's body — how can one claim to know everything? Of course one may call him 'All-knowing' (sarvavit) who knows the meaning of the word 'All' (sarva). Moreover, if Buddha is omniscient, why not Kapila? And if both, why the difference between their teachings? By practice one may jump about fifteen feet in the sky but surely one cannot jump over eight miles, though one may practice for innumerable times. It is said that the Buddha is like the Chintāmaṇi Jewel and when he sits in meditation, even the winds freely proclaim his teachings — such absurd statements can be believed only by those who have blind faith.

Śāntarakṣita and Kamalashīla's replies:

- It is wrong to say that because the Omniscient Being is not perceived therefore he does not exist. Mere non-apprehension cannot prove the non-existence of a thing. Even if his existence is not proved there should be only *doubt* about his existence, not certainty about his non-existence.
- Moreover, we maintain that an omniscient Being exists. He cannot be perceived by ordinary people. How can a person perceive the Omniscient unless he himself becomes Omniscient? Only the saints can directly realise him. Or the Omniscient Being, being Self-luminous, Himself sees Himself.
- We do not propound the existence of the Omniscient Being merely on the authority of the scripture — when the inferential mark is present, why should recourse be taken to verbal

testimony? In fact, omniscience is nothing else than the highest stage of knowledge.

- The young one of a regal swan cannot even come out of its nest. But through practice it can fly even across the ocean. Similarly a man by acquiring true knowledge through constant yogic practices can become the Buddha.

D. The Path to Liberation and the Buddha's Teaching as Validated by Reason

The Buddha for our benefit has proclaimed the doctrine of Nairātmya which is the unique Gateway to Bliss and which frightens the wrong doctrines. One who has realised this truth cannot be tainted with any defect — defect and truth, like darkness and light, are opposed to each other.

When there is no defect and no attachment, all 'coverings' of ignorance are removed and consequently Omniscience is realised and Oneness with the Buddha is attained. When the truth that Consciousness is the only reality and that ultimately there is no object (dharma-nairātmya) and no subject (pudgala-nairātmya) is realised, the cycle of birth-and-death comes to a standstill. This state is called **Apavarga**.

The Merciful Buddha has taught the right doctrine to everybody without making any distinction of any kind. The wise Brāhmaṇas pay their respects to the Omniscient Buddha. The real Brāhmaṇas are those who have removed all their sins by practising the teaching of Nairātmya — to be found in the religion founded by the Enlightened Sage.

The spurious Brāhmaṇas, unable to defend their wrong views by means of sound arguments, fall back upon the authority of the Veda. The Great Buddha, on the other hand, confident of his power to expound the right doctrine through reasonable arguments, curbing the arrogance of the maddened elephant-like opponents, fearlessly roars like a lion: **'O Bhikṣus, accept my words not out of mere respect for me, but after testing them at the touchstone of reason, just as gold is accepted as true by the wise after heating, cutting and rubbing against the touchstone.'**

End of Chapter Eight Notes — Svatantra-Vijñānavāda

Source: C. D. Sharma, A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy, Chapter 8, pp. 124-148